

Albatrosses

Ocean wanderers

Wingspan Up to 12 ft (3.6 m)

Range Southern oceans; North Pacific

Hunting technique Surface feeding

The biggest, most spectacular ocean birds are the albatrosses of southern oceans, with their enormously long wings. They have special adaptations that allow them to stay on the wing for days or even weeks at a time. The birds watch for squid and fish swimming near the surface and dip down to seize their prey in flight, but they may also settle on the water to feed.



Ocean birds

Some birds spend nearly all their lives out on the open ocean. The only reason they return to land is to find somewhere to nest, because they have to lay their eggs on solid ground. At sea they eat fish, squid, krill, and other sea creatures, and have evolved a variety of techniques for catching them. These range from snatching prey while flying over the surface to plummeting into the sea and even “flying” underwater.



Cormorants

Coastal hunters

Wingspan Up to 5 ft (1.5 m)

Range Coastal seas worldwide

Hunting technique Underwater pursuit

These coastal fish-eaters are specialized for hunting underwater, where they use their big webbed feet to drive themselves along. A cormorant's feathers absorb more water than those of most seabirds. This makes it less buoyant, helping it to stay submerged. As the bird gets very wet, it often has to hold its wings outspread to dry them off.

Gannets and boobies

High divers

Wingspan Up to 6 ft (1.8 m)

Range All tropical oceans; North Atlantic

Hunting technique Plunge diving

The most dramatic feeding technique has been perfected by gannets and boobies, such as this tropical blue-footed booby. They target fish from the air, and hurtle down to slice into the water at high speed with their wings swept back like arrowheads. The birds' vital organs are cushioned from the impact by air sacs under the skin. Once underwater, they seize their prey in their long, sharp bills before bursting back up into the air.

